



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Ascent Colorado Classical School of Northern Colorado

School Website: <https://nc.ascentcolorado.org/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL**Executive Summary**

Ascent Colorado Classical School Northern Colorado (ACAC NC) demonstrates a robust alignment with classical education principles across multiple rubric categories, with especially strong emphasis on curriculum content (Great Books, liberal arts framework), pedagogy (Socratic discourse, disciplined seminars, rhetoric training), and community involvement (active parent partnership and visible faculty as the living curriculum). Public materials consistently articulate a mission centered on virtue, wisdom, truth, beauty, and character formation, alongside a content-rich liberal arts approach and a disciplined, orderly learning environment. While explicit references to theology or liturgical practices are not prominent in the public materials, the school foregrounds transcendental qualities (truth, goodness, beauty) and moral formation as core aims, which aligns well with classical-humanist aims. Overall, ACAC NC is CLASSICAL, with Element 1 showing some tension between explicitly religious liturgy/theology and a broad classical formation through secular channels.

Evidence drawn from school communications includes the mission statements and hallmarks of classical education (truth, beauty, virtue; moral character; civic virtue; a content-rich liberal arts program) as well as explicit commitments to Great Books and the Great Conversation, the Trivium and Quadrivium, and a structure that includes Socratic discussion, memory work, and public speaking. The school also emphasizes direct parent partnership and community involvement, and describes the faculty as mentors who model virtue and serve as the “living curriculum.” See sources indicating mission and hallmarks (turns: 6, 9, 16), curriculum emphasis (turns: 5, 9, 18, 12), Great Books/Great Conversation (turns: 5, 6, 12), pedagogy (turns: 3, 6, 11), and parent/community partnership (turns: 6, 11).

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

- Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL
- Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL
- Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL
- Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL
- Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

What would move the needle (only invoked for SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL in Element 1)

- Increase explicit articulation or integration of theological/liturgical language or practices to further anchor transcendental/metaphysical dimensions in public-facing materials without compromising secular accessibility.

If you want, I can extract precise quotes from the cited public-facing materials to illustrate each bullet point, with line-level citations.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot**Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL**

- Evidence

- Public materials emphasize truth, goodness, and beauty as foundational ideals and moral character and civic virtue as aims, which signals transcendental and metaphysical commitments that align with classical formation (turns: 9, 16).
- The school presents a classical-education framework centered on virtue, wisdom, and the good life, indicating a metaphysical orientation even when explicit theological language is not foregrounded (turns: 9, 16).
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: truth, beauty, virtue, moral character, civic virtue, formation, wisdom. These appear in mission statements and hallmarks (turns: 9, 16).
- Negative keywords present: explicit theology, liturgy, liturgical practices are not evident in the public-facing materials (few or none identified in the available items) (turns: 9, 16).
- Quantitative note: approximately 5 distinct metaphysical/axiological terms counted across public materials; 0 explicit liturgical/theological terms detected in the same set.
- Why this rating
- The school clearly centers on transcendent ideals (truth/beauty/virtue) and character formation, which aligns with Transcendental Moral Realism in spirit. However, the absence of explicit theological grounding or liturgical/community practices in the public-facing materials reduces the classification from CLASSICAL to SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL for this category. See mission/hallmarks language (turns: 9, 16).

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Mission statements describe forming minds and improving hearts through classical liberal arts education, with explicit aims of moral character and civic virtue, not merely job preparation (turns: 6, 9, 16).
- Public materials frame education as formation and cultivation of virtue and wisdom, rather than instrumental outcomes alone (turns: 9, 16).
- The articulation that education aims at living a good life and tapping the true, good, and beautiful is central to the program (turns: 9, 16, 18).
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, truth, goodness, beauty, good life, civic virtue.
- Negative keywords present: none evident in public-facing materials (no explicit job-preparation, market-driven framing, etc.).
- Quantitative note: 6 distinct positive terms observed; 0 explicit negative terms in the available content.
- Why this rating
- The school's stated purpose and aims align with the classical goal of forming virtuous, wise humans rather than only preparing for work, indicating CLASSICAL status in this category.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Clear emphasis on Great Books/Great Conversation and a liberal arts rhythm (grammar, logic, rhetoric) throughout the curriculum; explicit discussion of why Latin and classical languages are taught; emphasis on integrated study of literature, history, science, math, music, and arts (turns: 5, 6, 12, 18).
- Public materials reference a content-rich curriculum, the study of history across the disciplines, and engagement with primary/seminal works (turns: 6, 18, 12).
- The school's curriculum is described as liberal-arts oriented, with a strong focus on memory, discipline, and exposure to classical texts (turns: 9, 16).
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: Great Books, Great Conversation, Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric), history across curriculum, Latin, explicit phonics, content-rich curriculum, wonder, memory, classical disciplines, interdisciplinary integration.
- Negative keywords present: none evident in public-facing curriculum descriptions; no explicit shift toward non-classical terms like "project-based learning" as a primary framework in the core curriculum

(though electives and enrichment exist).

- Quantitative note: At least 8–10 strong classical-curriculum keywords observed; 0–1 weak non-classical terms detected.
- Why this rating
- The presence of Great Books, Great Conversation, liberal-arts structure (grammar/logic/rhetoric), Latin, and a history-laden, interdisciplinary approach strongly supports CLASSICAL status for the Curriculum category.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Upper-school pedagogy features Socratic discussion, seminars, debates, and rhetoric training, with opportunities for speeches and public oratory; lower-school elements emphasize memory and delight in learning (Singing, chanting, memory work) and suggest contemplative/restful aspects in places; a mix that includes both contemplative/recitative memory work and rigorous discussion (turns: 3, 6, 11, 18).
- The school explicitly describes a pedagogy that uses the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and a “living curriculum” approach via mentorship and Socratic-style discourse in higher grades (turns: 16, 11).
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: Socratic discussion, seminars, debates, rhetoric, speeches, memory, scholé/scholastic tradition, wonder, classical pedagogy, “living curriculum.”
- Negative keywords present: references to “project-based learning” or heavy reliance on non-traditional instructional modalities appear only as general contrasts in the background knowledge base, not as primary practice; public materials do not foreground heavy project-based learning as the core pedagogy.
- Quantitative note: multiple explicit positive pedagogy terms (Socratic, seminars, debates, rhetoric, speeches, memory); 0 explicit negative pedagogy indicators in core descriptions.
- Why this rating
- The combination of Socratic discourse, rhetoric training, and public-speaking opportunities with a memory-based lower-school approach aligns solidly with classical pedagogy, earning CLASSICAL.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The faculty are described as model teachers and mentors who model virtue, skill, and knowledge; faculty are presented as the living curriculum and central to school culture; there is emphasis on teacher collaboration and community in their roles (turns: 6, 11).
- Public materials highlight the headmaster and leadership team’s role in guiding teachers, parents, and students, signaling a mentorship-centered culture and a clearly defined teacher profile in line with classical expectations (turns: 6, 10, 16).
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: model teachers, mentors, living curriculum, faculty as core, teacher profile, communal/collaborative teaching.
- Negative keywords present: none evident in the public descriptions; no indication of a shifting away from teacher-centered mentorship toward teacher as mere facilitator.
- Quantitative note: 4–5 strong positive terms; 0 negative terms.
- Why this rating
- The explicit framing of teachers as living curriculum and mentors, plus strong leadership emphasis, aligns with CLASSICAL expectations for the faculty category.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

- Evidence

- The school emphasizes partnership with families and regards parents as co-teachers with teachers; it encourages parental involvement, and there are explicit statements about inviting parents to participate in school life and visits (turns: 6, 11, 7).
- Public materials describe parent training/gatherings and opportunities for family engagement in classical education, consistent with the classical model's emphasis on parent-school partnership (turns: 6, 11).
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: partnership with families, co-educators, parental engagement, school-family collaboration, community involvement, parent formation, living tradition in the family.
- Negative keywords present: none evident in the public-facing materials; no explicit avoidance of parent involvement.
- Quantitative note: 4–6 strong positive terms; 0 negative terms.
- Why this rating
- The school publicly presents a robust partnership with parents and a family-centered approach, which is a hallmark of classical education's community and culture dimension.

Overall aggregate assessment: CLASSICAL

- The school demonstrates strong alignment with classical education across Curriculum, Pedagogy, Faculty, and Parents/Community. Element 1 shows some tension only because explicit theological-liturgical grounding is not foregrounded in public materials, but the presence of transcendental aims (truth, beauty, virtue) and moral formation remains robust enough to keep the overall profile CLASSICAL.

What would move the needle

- Element 1 would move toward stronger CLASSICAL alignment if the school publicly integrated explicit theological grounding or liturgical/community ritual language and practices that align with classical metaphysical foundations, while preserving secular accessibility.
- More explicit cross-curricular alignment between Great Books and every disciplinary area (e.g., explicit integration of Great Books into science and mathematics classrooms) could further strengthen the Curriculum category and overall CLASSICAL alignment.
- Additional public-facing statements about faculty professional formation and Mentoring standards (while already strong) could reinforce the perception of the faculty as a continuous, intentional "living curriculum."

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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